



new superstar will look to defend the Copa America on US soil.

Messi rejected a lucrative offer from Saudi Arabia, which became the new home for Cristiano Ronaldo, Neymar Jr., Karim Benzema, Jordan Henderson, Ruben Neves, and Firmino. The influx began with Ronaldo's move in January last year, when he switched allegiance to Al Nassr for a reported salary of \$213 million per year. In the following summer transfer window, Saudi clubs, which are bankrolled by the Public Investment Fund, splashed over a staggering \$1 billion in transfer fees alone. They also managed to turn the players' heads with vast amounts of salaries for a nation, where taxes are exempt for anyone who spends over two years.

But the Premier League remains the king. Halfway through the English top division, a potential multi-team title race emerges, reminiscent of 2008–09. At the time of going to press, the top five — Liverpool, Arsenal, Manchester City, Aston Villa, and Tottenham — are

Little hope, lot of fight: Indian football fans may have to temper their expectations as the men's national team participates in the Asian Cup in Qatar in January. GETTY IMAGES

closely packed, just five points apart.

The Premier League is getting richer and bigger every year, which was further reaffirmed by another Petro-dollar-fueled Manchester City's clean sweep in trophies across 2023 as the gulf further widens between the league and the rest of Europe. Real Madrid, Barcelona, and Juventus enjoyed a boost heading into the new year when their brainchild, the European Super League, received a lifeline after an E.U. Court of Justice's ruling threw out UEFA and FIFA's plans to blow the proposed league out of the water. But it remains to be seen how the league takes off if the English clubs with their array of top talent at their disposal stay away.

The summer of football peaked in Australia with the women's World Cup, shattering attendance and TV



Highlights of 2023

Manchester City won five trophies in the year 2023 — Premier League, FA Cup, UEFA Champions League, UEFA Super Cup, FIFA Club World Cup
Cristiano Ronaldo finished as the highest scorer with 54 goals
Barcelona won the La Liga for the first time since 2019
 ATK Mohun Bagan was renamed as **Mohun Bagan Super Giant** at the end of the 2022–23 season, when it won the ISL trophy
 The Premier League spent a **record-breaking** £2.36 billion on transfers in the 2022–23 summer transfer window